Angel Island – Words from the Barracks

Poetry translated by Genny Lim

(38 / #unknown; combined) Over a hundred poems
are on the walls.
They are all cries of suffering and sadness
What can one sad person say to another?
Gain or lose, how is one to know what is predestined?
Rich or poor, who is to say it is not the will of Heaven?
Why should one complain if he is detained and
imprisoned here?
From ancient times, heroes often were the first ones to
face adversity.
The day that I am rid of this prison and become
successful
I must remember that this chapter once existed . . .

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INTRODUCTION

Between 1910 and 1940 thousands of Chinese were detained and interrogated on Angel Island for weeks, months or years Separated from family, they lived in crowded, squalid communal living quarters. The ordeal left an indelible mark on the detainees. Their feelings of anger, frustration, uncertainty, hope and despair filled the walls of the detention barrack. Today more than 220 poems have been recorded and preserved. Most are undated and unsigned, presumably for fear of retribution.

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(10) ***Encouraging the Traveler***

Not without hard work were one thousand pieces of
gold dug up and gathered together.
There were words of farewell to the parents, but the
throat choked up first.
There were many feelings, many tears flowing face to
face, when parting with the wife.
Waves big as mountains often astonished this traveler.
Do not forget this day when you land ashore.
Push yourself ahead and do not be lazy or idle.

-- One Named Huie from Heungshan

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(7) Originally, I had intended to come to America last year.
I ate wind and tasted waves for more than twenty days.
Fortunately, I arrived safely on the American continent.
I thought I could land in a few days.
How was I to know I would become a prisoner suffering?
The barbarians' abuse is really difficult to take.
When my family's circumstances stir my emotions,
a double stream of tears flows.
I only wish I can land in San Francisco soon,
Thus sparing me this additional sorrow here.

(3) Sitting alone in the customs office,
How could my heart not ache?
Had my family not been poor,
I would not have traveled far away from home.
It was my elder brother who urged me
To embark on a voyage to this shore.
The black devil here is unjust-
He forces the Chinese to clean the floor.
Two meals a day are provided,

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But I wonder, when will I be homeward bound?

- Lee from Toishan District, September 4, 1911

(48) I thoroughly hate the barbarians because they do not respect justice.
They continually promulgate harsh laws to show off their prowess.
They oppress the overseas Chinese and also violate treaties.

(56) The young children do not yet know worry.
Arriving at the Golden Mountain, they were imprisoned in the wooden building.
Not understanding the sad and miserable situation before their eyes,
They must play all day like calves.

(24) ***Random Thoughts Deep at Night***
In the quiet of night, I heard, faintly, the whistling of wind.
The forms and shadows saddened me; upon seeing the landscape, I composed a poem.
The floating clouds, the fog, darken the sky.

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The moon shines faintly as the insects chirp.
Grief and bitterness entwined are heaven sent.
The sad person sits alone, leaning by a window.

--Written by Yee of Toishan

(24) After leaping into prison, I cannot come out.
From endless sorrows, tears and blood streak.
The Jingwei [1] bird carries gravel to fill its old grudge.
The migrating wild goose complains to the moon,
mourning his harried life.
When Ziqing [2] was in distant lands, who pitied and
inquired after him?
When Ruan Ji [3] reached the end of the road, he shed
futile tears.
The scented grass and hidden orchids complain of
withering and falling.
When may I be allowed to soar at my own pleasing?

-- Written by Lee Gengbo of Toishan

(43) Imprisoned in the wooden building day after day,
My freedom withheld; how can I bear to talk about it?
I look to see who is happy, but they only sit quietly.

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I am anxious and depressed and cannot fall asleep.
The days are long and the bottle constantly empty; my
sad mood, even so, is not dispelled.
Nights are long and the pillow cold; who can pity my
loneliness?
After experiencing such loneliness and sorrow,
Why not just return home and learn to plow the fields?

(49) I cannot bear to describe the harsh treatment
by the doctors.
Being stabbed for blood samples and examined for
hookworms[4] was even more pitiful.
After taking the medicine, I also drank liquid,
Like a dumb person eating the *huanglian.* [5]

(50) It is indeed pitiable the harsh treatment of our
fellow countrymen.
The doctor extracting blood caused us the greatest
anguish.
Our stomachs are full of grievances, but to whom can
we tell them?
We can but pace to and fro, scratch our heads, and

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question the blue sky.

(52) The barbarian issued orders to change rooms.
Running up and down, my breath grew short.
It was like warfare, when people's minds are bewildered.

(53) I have lingered here three days moving again and again.
It is difficult to compare this to the peacefulness at home.
Life need not be so demeaning.
Rushing about so much, smoke came out of my mouth.

(55) Shocking news, truly sad, reached my ears. We mourn you. When will they wrap your corpse for return?
You cannot close your eyes.
Whom are you depending on to voice your complaints?
If you had foresight, you should have regretted coming here.
Now you will be forever sad and forever resentful.
Thinking of the village, one can only futilely face the

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Terrace for Gazing Homeward.
Before you could fulfill your ambition, you were buried beneath clay and earth.
I know that even death could not destroy your ambition.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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NOTES

1 *A character in Chinese mythology. The daughter of Yandi, she died at a young age in the East Sea. After her death, she took the shape of a bird and filled the sea with twigs and stones in order to avenge her. Jingwei's relentless determination to fill the sea with pebbles is a symbol of resilience and the unwavering spirit of the Chinese people. It illustrates the idea that even in the face of insurmountable challenges, individuals should strive to make a difference, no matter how small or seemingly futile their efforts may appear.*

2 *Zhu Zihua was a renowned Chinese poet and essayist.*

3 *Ruan Ji, a poet and member of the Seven Sages, was executed by the state due to his independent thinking and disdain for court customs. His execution was met with strong protests from his thousands of followers.*

4 *Applicants for entry were examined for hookworm. During the earlier years, infestation with the parasite was cause for deportation. Later, patients were required to undergo medical treatment before landing.*

5 *A victim who cannot voice his complaints to anyone "huanglian" is a bitter herb.*

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